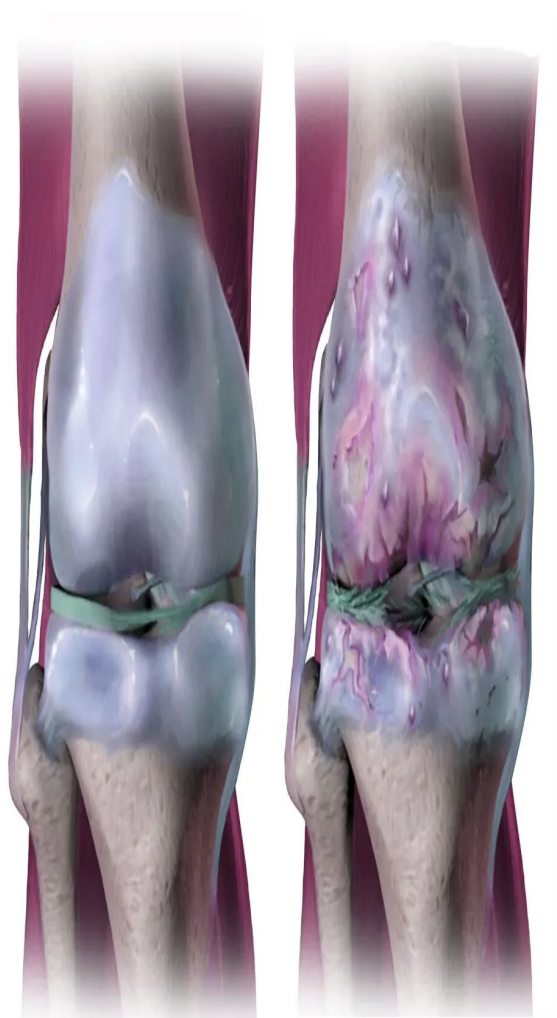


Hip Replacement Recovery Week by Week

A realistic 12-week timeline most people follow.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-22 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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A realistic 12-week timeline most people follow.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]\(/exercises/hip\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Large-scale reviews of medical studies consistently show that hip replacement surgery significantly improves pain and mobility for most people with severe hip arthritis. These reviews, which combine data from many individual trials, highlight the long-term effectiveness of the procedure. Clinical guidelines from leading UK bodies support hip replacement as a highly successful treatment option when non-surgical approaches are no longer effective.

The evidence also strongly emphasises the importance of rehabilitation after surgery. Systematic reviews demonstrate that a structured exercise programme, often with input from a physiotherapist, leads to better recovery outcomes, including improved walking ability and greater strength. While individual results vary, consistent participation in your prescribed exercises is key to regaining full function.

Furthermore, research indicates that educating patients about what to expect during recovery, including potential challenges and milestones, can significantly reduce anxiety and improve satisfaction with the overall experience. This patient education, combined with strong support from family and healthcare professionals, contributes to a more positive and successful recovery journey.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Doing too much too soon:** Thinking you're fully recovered early on and overdoing activities. *Listen to your body and stick to your exercise plan without rushing.*

* **Neglecting exercises:** Skipping your prescribed physiotherapy exercises because you feel well or are busy. *These exercises are crucial for strength and flexibility; make them a daily priority.*

* **Ignoring pain signals:** Pushing through sharp or increasing pain, believing it's a necessary part of recovery. *Differentiate between muscle soreness and warning signs; consult your physiotherapist if pain is worsening.*

* **Poor posture and movement habits:** Falling back into old ways of moving that put strain on your hip. *Be mindful of your posture and gait, especially when sitting or lifting.*

* **Expecting immediate perfection:** Becoming disheartened if progress isn't perfectly linear or as fast as you hoped. *Recovery is a journey with ups and downs; celebrate small victories.*

When to Speak to a Clinician

While some discomfort and swelling are normal after hip replacement surgery, specific symptoms warrant prompt attention from your GP, physiotherapist, or rheumatologist. It's important not to delay if you experience any of these red flags, as early intervention can prevent complications and support your recovery. Your healthcare team is there to help guide you safely through this process.

* Sudden, severe pain in your hip or leg that isn't eased by rest or medication. * New or increasing redness, warmth, or discharge around your incision site. * Fever (a temperature of 38°C or higher) accompanied by chills. * Significant, unexplained swelling in your operated leg, particularly if only in one leg. * Sudden difficulty bearing weight or a noticeable change in your leg length. * Shortness of breath or chest pain.

Frequently Asked Questions

How long until I can walk without crutches? Most people gradually reduce their reliance on walking aids over the first 2-6 weeks after surgery. Your physiotherapist will guide you on when it's safe to progress, depending on your strength and stability. It's important not to rush this process to prevent falls and allow proper healing.

Can I drive after a hip replacement? Generally, you can start driving again once you can comfortably get in and out of the car, operate the pedals safely (especially if it's your right hip), and perform an emergency stop without pain. This typically takes around 6 weeks, but your surgeon will give you specific advice. Always check with your insurance provider too.

When can I return to my usual activities and hobbies? Low-impact activities like swimming, cycling on a stationary bike, and walking can often be resumed within 6-12 weeks, as advised by your physiotherapist. More demanding activities, such as gardening, golf, or dancing, might take 3-6 months. High-impact sports are generally not recommended after a hip replacement to protect the joint.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about hip replacement recovery week by week?

Short answer: After hip replacement, most people gradually reduce walking aid reliance over 2-6 weeks. Driving may resume around 6 weeks, depending on comfort and being able to perform an emergency stop. Low-impact activities are often possible within 6-12 weeks, while more demanding hobbies can take 3-6 months. High-impact sports are generally not recommended.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk